Usha Thorat, former Deputy Governor of the RBI,[52] summed it up succinctly: 'It is indeed a sad day to see one of the most respected public institutions in India becoming an object of ridicule and scorn. There have been times when the Old Lady of Mint Street was criticised for being too conservative and cautious – for not being able to keep up with innovation and markets – but never has she been accused of not knowing her job. Never has she been the butt of as many jokes as in the last few days… Doubts have been expressed on the double counting of old notes returned to the RBI. There are press reports that the data furnished by the RBI on notes issued between 10 December and 19 December do not tally between the pieces and values. Data on notes returned to the RBI after 12 December has not been officially released – *this is generating enormous speculation whether the notes returned exceed the notes issued*. The RBI would do well to release every week, say, every Monday, data on the notes issued, denomination and value-wise, as also on old notes returned, to set all speculation to rest.'[53]

Putting in words what many had suspected, Thorat summed up the RBI's dilemma. The government's stated prime rationale for the note ban was extinguishing black money. However, as the country deposited its cash into the banks, it was soon clear that practically all the money that had been demonetized was coming back into the system. This could mean only three things:

- There was no black money
- That whatever black money there was, had been converted into white money
- That the RBI data was wrong

Given that the first two options were unlikely, it seemed that the RBI was being pushed into a corner with respect to the third.

Media speculated that the repeated about-turns in policy, the 19 November notification of the ₹5,000 deposit limit, and the restrictions